

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, May 14, 2025, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Girard at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward II Councilor Brian Zutter
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Hayden
Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor William Greenrose
At-Large Councilor Wayne Hemingway
At-Large Councilor William Limoges
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Mayor Dale Girard

Also present:

Nancy Bates, Interim City Manager
Brent Wilmot, Interim City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

Mayor Girard removed item A. under Old Business Resolution 2025-49.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept the minutes of the April 23, 2025, City Council meeting.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – abstain

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0, 1 abstained

A motion was made by Councilor Hemingway and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept the minutes of the April 21, 2025, City Council meeting.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

MAYOR’S NOTES

Claremont Parks and Recreation is hosting a movie night this Saturday at the visitors center at 8pm.

Next Monday the first small business Monthly Round Table at the Visitors Center starting at 10am.

The American Legion parade will be held Monday May 26, 2025, starting at 10 am followed by a celebration.

May is American Wetlands month, the conservation commission in Newport is holding a presentation at their community center on May 20th at 6:30 pm.

Councilor Hayden noted the Conservation Commission will be hosting a create a pollinator garden presentation at the Visitors Center from 6:30 pm to 7:30 pm.

Councilor Limoges noted the wall that heals committee will have a meeting at 6:15 pm next Tuesday at the community center.

CITY MANAGER’S REPORT

Chief Wilmot stated yesterday afternoon Joel Tremblay was laid to rest, and our hearts go out to his family and co-workers.

The Storage tank in front of city hall will be removed on May 19th parking will be changed during this time. The handicap parking will be on the other side of the building.

DPW partnered with Girl Scouts for smoking receptacles, Girl Scouts will be managing and cleaning them, and materials inside will be recycled. Plaques will be put up.

Former Mayor, Lovett sent an update for the Amtrack station and is excited to give a presentation on all the updates after the start of the new fiscal year.

Tomorrow is Peace Officers Memorial Day.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

CCTV

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to appoint Kevin Tyson to Seat 3 of the CCTV Board of Directors.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – no

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-1

Energy Advisory Committee

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Limoges to Tom Luther to Seat 2 of the Energy Advisory Committee.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0

A motion was made by Councilor Greenrose and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to appoint Kevin Tyson to Seat 4 of the Energy Advisory Committee.

Voice vote:
Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0

Frances J Tolles Home

Councilor Koloski wants these new members to have formal training from legal; Mayor Girard noted the Council representative can work with them.

Mayor Girard asked for a roll call with names of applicants’ councilors would like to be appointed.

Roll call:
Koloski – Eric Rouleau and Bette Pfenning
Greenrose – Eric Rouleau and Bette Pfenning
Limoges - Eric Rouleau and Bette Pfenning
Matteau – Eric Rouleau and Bette Pfenning
Zutter – Kathleen Ericson and Lawrence Johnson
Hemingway – Eric Rouleau and Bette Pfenning
Hayden – Eric Rouleau and Bette Pfenning
O’Hearne – Eric Rouleau and Bette Pfenning
Girard – Eric Rouleau and Bette Pfenning
Motion carried - Eric Rouleau for a three year term and Bette Pfenning for a one-year term 8-1

Parks and Recreation Commission

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Greenrose to re-appoint Allyn Girard to Seat 3 At Large of Parks and Recreation Commission.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway - yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – opposed

Girard – recused

Motion carried 7-1

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Mayor Girard gave reminder that Citizen’s forum is designed to allow you the opportunity to make the Council aware of your concerns. Please state your name and ward number, we ask you to address your concerns directly to the Council. The Council Manager will not be responding to you during this time. You are limited to five minutes on any non-agenda items. In the back of the room please write down your contact information if you’d like to be contacted as well as your concern on the clipboard for follow-up.

Bonnie miles, Ward II shared concern for outdoor furniture on pleasant street. It’s been approved to be on pleasant street and wants it back there.

Norm Blouin, Ward III, stated the city should use the last budget and freeze this one. The City needs a manager that is capable of budget and wants less frills because this is not a rich town, and stated people are just getting by and if the City keeps raising taxes it will be a pile of bricks the City needs to better justify spending its money. Mr. Blouin also had a concern for East Green Mountain Road and suggested it be crowned in calcium. Mr. Blouin noted the list of roads for paving; all don’t need to be paved; other roads need it more and agrees with a 5% cut to the budget.

Councilor Koloski agrees his road isn’t a priority, but there was a citizen’s petition.

NEW BUSINESS

White Water Brook Dam Discussion (City Planner/Director of Public Works)

City Planner, Austin Ford and Department of Public Works Director, Alex Gleeson updated the public on the White-Water Brook Dam.

City Planner noted this has been on his radar since before working at the city and is concerned about overhearing conversations that are held around misinformation and fear. High hazard classification of the dam has nothing to do with the condition of the dam; it refers to what is downstream of the dam and what may happen if the dam is to be breached. The dam is inspected every two years, and will be updating hazard mitigation this year, there are meetings for the public to be educated to the process. Any concerns are encouraged to be brought up with the City Planner.

Resolution 2025-50 79E 32-40 Pleasant Street – Public Hearing (City Manager/City Planner)

City Planner Ford, explained the 79-E Application and noted eight new residential units are proposed and all have necessary approval from historic, planning, and zoning.

By Consensus Council agrees to a July 1, 2025, start date with a March 31, 2026 completion date, and accepted 7 years for the 79-E.

A motion was made by Councilor Hayden and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept resolution 2025-50.

Applicant Matthew Bacon noted there is a new LLC 1852 MB3240 LLC, City Planner Ford is comfortable with that change.

Councilor Hayden read Resolution 2025-50 into record.

Councilor O’Hearne has a concern that there is no documentation with the new LLC name.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Koloski- thanked Mr. Bacon for the investment in our community.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – no

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-1

Resolution 2025-51 Safe Streets and Roads Grant Match – Public Hearing

By consensus the Council agrees to bring this item back on the City Council May 28th Meeting.

Resolution 2025-52 Overspend the 411 and 412 Salary Line – Public Hearing

Chief Wilmot explained this is for the increase for Chief and Director Bates during their time as Interim City Managers, and this is to seek approval but will not exceed the overall 2025 budget line.

Councilor Zutter asked if council approves line items.

Mayor Girard explained Director Bates didn't feel comfortable accepting her own increase.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept resolution 2025-52.

Councilor Koloski read Resolution 2025-52 into the record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O'Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Resolution 2025-53 Land and Water Conservation Fund 'LWCF' Grant Acceptance – Public Hearing (City Manager/Director of Parks and Recreation)

Director Martin explained Resolution 2025-53.

A motion was made by Councilor Zutter and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept resolution 2025-53.

Councilor Zutter read Resolution 2025-52 into the record.

Mayor Dale Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Budget

a. Parks and Recreation

Director Martin shared a presentation – and gave an overview of Parks and Recreation and read their mission statement.

After Discussion the council had the following concerns:

A modular sign for arrowhead, pass through lines for ARC, regular pay increase and would like to see this lowered, building Maintenance and repair only being at \$8,000 but is requesting \$35,000. Concerns for using the Maintenance and Repair line for cement slabs at the dog park, and missing revenues for arrowhead,

Councilor Greenrose asked why the total appropriations are coming in under budget but a larger requested increase.

Director Martin noted this year there are significant projects that still need to be done by June 30th, and is anticipating spending this budget.

Councilor Koloski would like to see a break down for arrowhead. As well as a breakdown from the schools, and a breakdown of all monies owed to the city to keep things clean and transparent.

Councilor Hayden wants to drop building maintenance to \$30K because we can use dog park funds for the cement slabs, this would take off \$5000 from Building M&R.

Mayor Girard shared concerns for revenue items, and noted regular pay should be in the \$85K range. The temp and seasonal positions haven't been used in two years and thinks this should be removed.

Mayor Girard would like to see part-time reduced, and wants to see Building M&R reduced to \$20K because the playgrounds are in decent condition.

Councilor Koloski doesn't want to TA this budget because there are too many unanswered questions.

Mayor Girard shared concerns about the youth baseball and softball field, and noted these shouldn't change as money was just spent on it and that would be a waste tax payer money.

Mayor Girard stated he will gather a list of follow up questions and send them to the City Managers.

By consensus the Council will ring back the Parks Budget.

b. CSB Community Center

Councilor Limoges has concerns about equipment replacement and thinks this should be put off this year.

Councilor Koloski suggested a task force for the Community Center

Assistant Mayor Matteau agrees a task force is a good idea.

Mayor Girard had concerns about revenue.

By Consensus Council agrees to bring back Community Center Budget.

c. Welfare

Director Carr gave an overview of welfare and stated there is a request for a significant increase, and noted as of today Welfare has expended \$230K, with another \$14K in the pipeline.

Councilor Hemingway questioned if the rent line can be increased if Director Carr comes back to Council later in the year to request it if needed.

Director Carr understood the reasoning but explained at some point in the future what happens if there isn't any money in the Fund Balance.

Councilor Koloski thinks the increase is needed and predicts even more will be needed.

Councilor Greenrose noted the jump in rent and asked if these are from people who have been residents in Claremont. Director Carr explained its the cost of rents increasing, and when there is no more room in a shelter having to put clients into motels.

Mayor Girard thinks this needs to be looked at harder before final approval.

A motion was made by Council Greenrose and seconded by Councilor Hayden to tentatively Accept the Welfare Budget. For \$568,864.00 plus 15k in revenue.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O'Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

d. Library

Director Grace shared highlights for the library.

Councilor Koloski would like to get a total amount for capital reserve account for library during final budget vote.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to tentatively accept the Library Budget for \$436,890.00.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Charter Amendment Discussion – Residency Clause for City Manager (City Manager/City Council)

By Consensus the Council agrees to have a public hearing on the May 28th, 2025 Council Meeting.

City Manager Hiring Process Discussion (City Manager/City Council)

Human Resource Director, Shannon Thibodeau put together information to make an informed Decision on which route to take for the search of a new City Manager, and noted she has worked in Human Resources and recruiting for 25 years. The information packet will be sent to Council.

The First option is MRI and they have two models. One is a direct hire which is about \$15K-\$20K and a support model costing around \$5K.

Another option, and an option Director Thibodeau is more comfortable with is purchasing a sourcing tool this allows the ability to jump into a database to grab as many candidates as possible.

Director Thibodeau noted there would be LinkedIn and Indeed and gave the breakdown on both costs.

Director Thibodeau’s suggestion is LinkedIn, and by purchasing this we could have a “seat” all year which could also help with the search for the Planning and Development Director.

Councilor Greenrose asked if LinkedIn is well represented on the municipal side as it is on the

corporate side.

Councilor Limoges agrees with LinkedIn, and noted being disappointed with the MRI candidates last time.

Councilor Zutter shared he has had success with indeed, but either way does like the plan to use Director Thibodeau to aide in the search process.

Councilor Koloski wants to see the cost differences, and an organizational breakdown.

Mayor Girard suggested a better list of qualities, and stated the City will probably have to pay more than ever planned on.

Councilor Koloski had concerns for funds expended for interviews to fly candidates here and stay here, Councilor would like to use remote access as much as possible but does think they should come here and tour beforehand to make sure they think they're a good fit as well.

By Consensus the Council agrees to share the information and have Director Thibodeau aide in the search process.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Councilor Limoges noted the CDA is still dealing with the roof at 56 Opera House Sq., and the 3 Tremont Street leak.

Assistant Mayor Matteau noted the Planning Board approved a site plan for two commercial spaces. 132 Elm St from a 1 family to a duplex and discussed zoning amendments to sober housing which will be coming to council.

Councilor Hemingway noted the ZBA had an application to increase density on Royce St. and Central St, and there was an expansion approved for Old Church Road.

Mayor Girard noted the Airport Committee met last month, there will be a project coming in front of council soon, and a lease that was approved last meeting is moving ahead there is an excavator on site.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Assistant Mayor Matteau would like to see the Pleasant Street chairs back on Pleasant Street before winter.

Councilor Hemingway has concerns for kids on highspeed scooters not wearing helmets/reflective gear sidewalks and roads.

Councilor Koloski wants to look into how much a guard rail or timber fence would be for Fire and will there be parking lot striping. Councilor Koloski wants a Community Center task force, and a housing task force. Mentioning the Licensing Board lacks a citizen on this board.

Councilor Koloski wants the project engineer to have more authority on projects. Councilor Koloski would like an update on the Claremont City Welcome sign that was hit on main street.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 10:14 p.m., a motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Councilor Zutter to adjourn.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Respectfully Submitted,

Julia A. Bizzarro
Clerk to the Council